

- Change the permission to Don't allow, Ask every time, or Allow only while using, depending on the app.
- Repeat this every few weeks.

This is especially useful after installing new apps, travelling, attending events, testing unknown apps for work, or handing your phone to someone else.

Approximate location is your friend

Not every app needs your exact location. A weather app can usually work with approximate location. A news app does not need to know your precise lane. A restaurant app may need nearby area, not your exact building. Android's approximate location option is useful because it lets apps function without giving them unnecessary precision.

Use precise location for maps, ride-hailing, delivery in progress, navigation, safety apps and anything where accuracy is essential. Use approximate location for weather, local content, search and many lifestyle apps. Deny location entirely to apps where location adds nothing.

This is not about paranoia. It is about proportionality. The app should receive data proportional to the service it provides.

Photos, videos and file access

Older Android habits trained users to think of storage access as one giant cupboard. Newer Android versions increasingly push apps toward more limited access, such as selecting specific photos or videos. Use that where available. A profile photo upload does not require lifelong access to your entire gallery. A document upload does not need every folder on your phone.

Be particularly careful with apps that request broad file access. File managers need it. Backup tools may need it. Some office or scanning apps may need limited document access. But games, wallpaper apps, sticker apps and random editors do not automatically deserve it.



CAMERA AND MICROPHONE INDICATORS

Android can also warn you in real time when the camera or microphone is active. Google's Android help says that when apps use your camera or microphone, a green indicator appears at the top right of the screen. Swiping down and tapping the indicator shows which app or service is using it, and tapping again lets you manage permissions.



Do not ignore this indicator. If you are in a video call, it is expected. If you are recording audio, expected. If you are using the camera, expected. But if the indicator appears while you are reading a news article, playing a game, browsing a shopping app or sitting on the home screen, investigate.

Also remember that screenshots can contain sensitive data: UPI receipts, addresses, tickets, IDs, account details, email snippets and private chats. Your gallery is not just memories. It is evidence of your life.

Google Play Data safety is useful, not magical

Before installing an app, scroll through its Play Store listing. Google Play's Data safety section lets developers describe how their apps collect, share and handle different types of data. Google's help page explains that this section is meant to help users understand app privacy and security practices before downloading.

Use it as a signal, not a guarantee. If an app's Data safety section says it collects location, contacts, financial info or identifiers, ask whether that makes sense. Also check the developer name, update history, reviews, number of downloads and whether the app is a clone. A fake-looking "banking helper" or "KYC update" app should not get the benefit of the doubt.

The safest app is often the one you never install.

Sideloaded and unknown apps

Android allows more freedom than many platforms, including installing apps from outside the Play Store. That freedom is